Thaitwari, Janglikh and Dhamwari in Rohru; Khaltu Nala and some areas of Kotkhai and Kumarsein and Chini Bangla in Kufri. In Shimla city, the sinking zones included areas of Comley Bank, Krishna Nagar, the Police Lines area in Kaithu, Jutog Cantt, Dhingu Dhar near Dhalli, the Fruit Apple Mandi in Bhattakuffer and areas near the ISBT (inter-state bus terminal). This is about 25 per cent of the city. The local corporation data show that over 10,000 buildings still don't have the requisite permissions.

The challenge that most bureaucrats underline is in construction that is unregulated or regulated later. Hence, it lacks proper drainage and the storm water (the rain water runoff) is recharged in the hills. "This makes the hills vulnerable...buildings shouldn't get water and power connections if they do not have a proper drainage system in place," says state BJP spokesperson Chetan Bragta. "Shimla desperately needs to be decongested. You can't expand the limits, regularise illegal constructions and then expect that 'all will be well'," says environmentalist and former additional chief secretary of the state Avay Shukla.





RAJWANT RAWAT

SWEPT AWAY A damaged rail track at Summer Hill; (below) remnants of a slaughter house that was washed away in Krishna Nagar

A CONTENTIOUS FUTURE

The previous Jairam Thakur-led BJP government had approved the draft Shimla Development Plan, 'Vision 2041' in February 2022, but the National Green Tribunal (NGT) had stayed it, saying it was illegal and in conflict with orders passed in 2017 to regulate construction in Shimla. It was approved again by the Sukhvinder Singh cabinet after the Supreme Court lifted the stay on May 3. As expected, Vision 2041 has become quite contentious, with environmentalists across the spectrum opposing it tooth and nail, more so because it would pave the way for construction in 17 green belts (with some restrictions) and also in the core area where the NGT had banned building activity.

The plan draws from the hypothesis that the population of the city's planned area will expand to 650,000. Among other things, it proposes to develop the Jubbarhatti and Ghandal areas as activity-based 'counter-magnet towns' with a provision for adequate urban amenities, such as education, health, trade and commerce. Alongside, there will be satellite townships in Ghandal, Fagu, Naldehra and the Chamiyana area near the four-lane bypass, to decongest the core area and accommodate the extra population and commercial activities.

Another proposal is to move some of the government departments out of Shimla to these new locations. Currently, state government employees and their family members alone make up about 50,000 of Shimla's population. The environmentalists argue that it will only create more pressure as many may not move out of Shimla. They are pushing for a roadmap to decongest, cut down the population